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Redesign of the branding of a horror film

BACHELOR THESIS

Study programme: Multimedia in the Economic Practice

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Abstract

This bachelor thesis focuses on creating a modern branding for the horror film *Suspiria* (1977) that ensures genre recognizability while being visually appealing to contemporary audiences. The theoretical part analyses a curated selection of horror movie posters from different decades to identify recurring visual elements that regularly appear in horror posters and help viewers recognise the genre. These insights form the basis for understanding which visual cues support genre recognition and can be effectively incorporated into a contemporary redesign. The thesis also discusses the role of film branding and posters as essential carriers of visual identity. The practical part develops a new branding concept for *Suspiria*, consisting of a poster, a Blu-ray collector's edition, and a vinyl record design. The design process draws on visual research, mood boards, and exploration of multiple conceptual directions before establishing a final cohesive visual identity. To evaluate whether the new branding achieves genre recognizability and visual appeal, an online survey was conducted. The results indicate that the redesigned materials communicate the atmosphere and genre features of horror well and are also perceived as visually appealing by contemporary viewers. Overall, the thesis demonstrates a coherent branding solution for *Suspiria* that functions effectively across the poster, Blu-ray edition, and vinyl release.

Keywords

horror, film, branding, poster, A24, *Suspiria*

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Introduction

Branding plays an important role in how audiences understand a film, especially within the horror genre, where atmosphere and visual symbolism shape viewer expectations. Horror films often use recognisable visual cues that help audiences identify the genre, even when the style or decade varies.

The decision to focus on the redesign of the branding for *Suspiria* (1977), directed by Dario Argento, is based on the film's exceptional stylistic qualities and the author's longstanding interest in visual communication within cinema, particularly within the horror genre. As a graphic designer, the author is especially interested in how films communicate with audiences visually, and this project therefore represents an opportunity to connect academic research with creative practice. Although *Suspiria* (1977) is widely recognised for its visual and cultural significance, the film does not possess a coherent modern branding or a unified system of promotional materials.

This thesis focuses on the redesign of the branding for the 1977 horror film *Suspiria*, directed by Dario Argento. The film was chosen due to its exceptional stylistic qualities, its significant cultural influence within horror cinema. The aim of this thesis is to create a modern branding for *Suspiria* that ensures genre recognizability while being visually appealing to contemporary audiences. A secondary outcome is the development of a vinyl record design and a Blu-ray collector's edition, which apply the new branding across additional formats. The thesis is guided by the following research question: How can modern branding for a horror film be designed to communicate the horror genre to contemporary audiences?

To achieve the aim, several methods were applied. The theoretical part uses visual and content analysis of selected horror posters from different decades, a comparative approach to identifying recurring genre cues, and a case study of studio A24 to understand contemporary branding strategies. The practical part applies a design-based research method, combining sketching and concept development. Finally, a quantitative online survey with 44 respondents is conducted to evaluate how effectively the new branding communicates the film's genre and aesthetic qualities.

Data for the theoretical part of the thesis were collected from publicly accessible sources, while respondents for the survey were reached through social media platforms.

The structure of the thesis reflects the logic of this methodological approach. The theoretical part examines branding in the film industry, with a particular focus on how films communicate their identity through graphic design elements. It also analyses a curated selection of horror movie posters from different decades to identify recurring visual elements that commonly indicate the horror genre. The role of the poster as the primary carrier of a film's branding is discussed in greater detail in a later section. Furthermore, the analysis continues with an examination of contemporary branding practices through a focused case study of Studio A24. A24 is examined in detail because it exemplifies how contemporary films build coherent brand identities that extend far beyond the poster and into merchandise, collectible editions, and other physical and digital promotional materials.

The practical part of the thesis focuses on the process of creating new branding for *Suspiria*. It includes visual research, mood board development, exploration of alternative concepts, and the creation of final designs applied to the poster, Blu-ray edition, and vinyl record. To evaluate whether the new branding meets the aims, an online survey with 44 respondents was conducted to investigate genre recognizability, visual appeal, and consistency across formats.

The contribution of this thesis lies in proposing a coherent contemporary branding approach for *Suspiria* and demonstrating how key visual cues associated with the horror genre can be incorporated into modern promotional materials.

1 Theoretical part

The theoretical part of this thesis examines the foundations of film branding, with a particular focus on how branding operates within the horror genre. The chapter begins by outlining the principles of branding in cinema and how films establish recognisable visual identities. It also explains why the poster functions as the primary carrier of a film's branding.

A brief section also outlines Italian horror and the giallo tradition, providing essential context for *Suspiria* and its original visual language.

The theoretical part will involve an analysis of horror movie posters from different decades, exploring commonly used visuals, popular aesthetics, and prevailing trends. By identifying recurring patterns, the theoretical part establishes a contextual framework for understanding how horror films have been visually positioned in different historical periods.

Another part of the theoretical chapter examines contemporary branding practices, with a focus on the independent studio A24. Its approach illustrates how films can function as brands through extended branding.

1.1 The Poster as the Primary Carrier of a Film's Branding

Branding in the film industry is understood as a set of strategies and practices aimed at ensuring film recognition and maintaining its presence within the media environment. A cinematic brand is a system that helps shape the long-term value of a film. Since modern film exists as a multi-platform product and no longer functions solely as a standalone audiovisual object, the industry uses a wide range of branding elements (Grainge, 2007).

This paper focuses on the visual component of this system, the branding elements that form a viewer's first impression through graphic design. Specifically, this paper examines the film poster as the main element of visual identity and explores how its design can be adapted for physical releases, such as collectible Blu-ray editions and vinyl records.

The poster is traditionally regarded as one of the central tools in establishing a film's visual identity, as it significantly influences viewer choice by helping audiences navigate available options and decide what to watch. Poster design therefore plays a crucial role in this decision-making process (Pooranalingam, 2024). Complementary releases, such as Blu-ray collector's editions and vinyl records, function as extensions of an already established visual identity. They incorporate the key stylistic features of the poster into the merchandise, resulting in unified and recognisable visual branding for the film. Research also shows that audience engagement with poster design is not limited to aesthetic appreciation but directly correlates with viewing behaviour. A measurable relationship exists between how much viewers like a poster, their willingness to seek information about the film, and their eventual decisions to watch or purchase tickets. In other words, stronger positive reactions to a poster significantly increase the likelihood of audience interest and attendance (Jiang, 2023).

1.2 Historical Overview of Visual Branding in Horror

Writing this thesis requires understanding the historical background and the evolution of branding in the horror genre. Before creating the branding for the *Suspiria* relaunch, examining how horror branding has evolved over the decades was necessary. After all, this genre attracts people through emotions like fear and anxiety, which means that visual elements are more important here than in many other genres. In the case of any horror film, the posters are not just images. They are how the film speaks to the viewer — setting the tone and the mood (Yang, 2023).

To minimise the influence of subjective authorial preferences when selecting films for inclusion in the analysis, a list compiled by the trade magazine *Variety* (Adlakha et al., 2024) was used as the starting point. This list, created by the editorial team and professional film critics, includes *The 100 Greatest Horror Movies of All Time*. From this list, 15 films were selected and arranged in chronological order, beginning with *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920) and ending with *Get Out* (2017). As a long-established and influential publication in the film industry, *Variety* offers rankings created by experienced critics, making it a reliable reference for identifying key works within the genre. To further reduce subjective influence, films were chosen randomly within each decade using a randomiser tool and then reviewed to ensure that one or two representative titles were included per period. This approach made it possible to form a sample that is both diverse and manageable within the scope of this thesis.

The discussion of poster design begins with *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920), a silent horror film that served as a gateway to German Expressionist cinema (Robinson, 2013). German Expressionist cinema is visually defined by intentionally unrealistic set designs: distorted shapes, crooked doors and windows, and artificial, painted shadows. These stylised elements create a disorienting and unsettling atmosphere, which became one of the movement's most recognisable characteristics. Expressionism strongly influenced cinematographic techniques and visual aesthetics across creators, genres, and periods, shaping the look of global cinema and particularly the horror genre (Millikan, 2021). Within this stylistic context, the poster for *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* reflects the core visual features of Expressionism. Distorted forms, sharp angles and an exaggerated, theatrical portrayal of the monster immediately stand out.



Figure 1: Movie poster for *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920)

Eleven years later, *Dracula* (1931) was released, and despite the time gap, it still shows the same theatrical style in how the main antagonist is presented. The poster, like those of many films from that period, is illustrated. When examining the posters for *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* and *Dracula*, a clear pattern appears: the primary focus is the villain, usually shown together with a possible victim. The poster for *Dracula* also includes a slogan that draws in the viewer and offers at least a minimal context or general idea of what the film promises.



Figure 2: Movie poster for *Dracula* (1931)

The poster features a large portrait of Dracula, with a sinister expression and tense brows. His gaze is directed to the side, and his face is unnaturally brightly illuminated by a light source positioned below. The colour palette is dominated by cool blue tones contrasted with red and orange accents. A large red-and-yellow text with distorted lettering takes up a large part of the composition. Overall, the poster centres on the dominant image of the villain, his threatening gaze, and the contrast between the cool palette and warm accents.

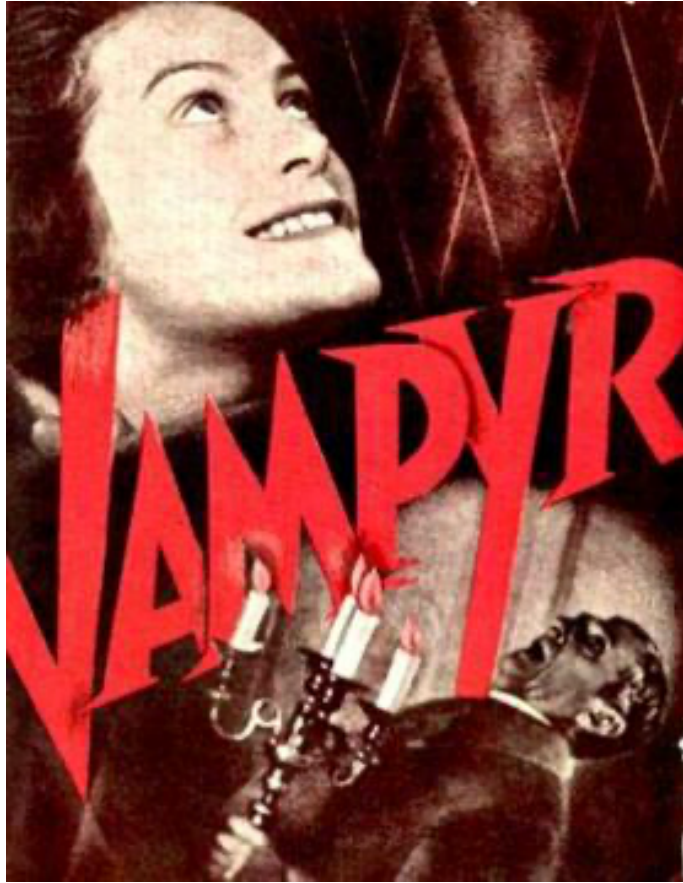


Figure 3: Movie poster for *Vampyr* (1932)

The film poster for *Vampyr* (1932) features a large image of a woman's face at the top. The film title is styled in massive, angular, broken letters that evoke the motif of sharp vampire teeth. The typography dominates the composition and is further emphasized by its vibrant red colour, while the rest of the image remains monochrome.



Figure 4: Movie poster for *Cat People* (1942)

The *Cat People* poster combines a large image of a cat with a standing female figure. Blood drips from the cat's mouth, making it appear more sinister. The sharp teeth serve as a visual accent, intensifying the sense of danger. The colour scheme features deep greens and blues, with blood red used as a highlight on the animal's mouth and the heroine's dress. The typography consists of smooth, rounded forms that are occasionally distorted with jagged edges.



Figure 5: Movie poster for *Horror of Dracula* (1958)

The *Horror of Dracula* poster is designed in an illustrative style. The vampire is shown bending over his victim, a fair-haired woman in a white dress, which emphasises her vulnerability. The colour palette is dominated by rich reds and greenish-yellow tones. The

typography features a jagged outline, which contributes to the poster's chaotic and uneasy mood.



Figure 6: Movie poster for *The Blob* (1958)

In the composition of *The Blob* (1958) poster, the characters are placed in the lower part, while most of the space is devoted to the image of an amorphous, blood-red mass looming over the people and overtaking them. The face of the girl in the foreground clearly expresses fear of the approaching threat. The film title appears in large, blurred letters with sharp edges, occupying almost the entire upper half of the composition and playing a key role in its visual balance. The colour palette includes black, green, red, and yellow tones.

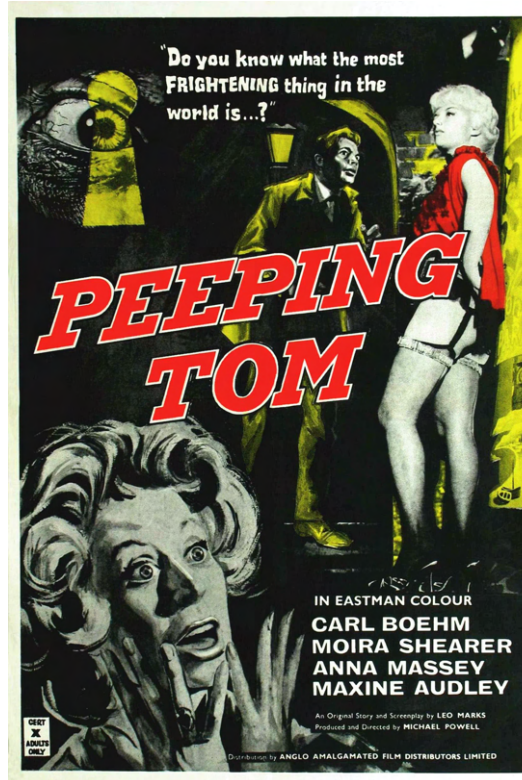


Figure 7: Movie poster for *Peeping Tom* (1960)

The *Peeping Tom* poster is created in a collage-like manner and combines several visual elements: a close-up of a woman's face expressing fear, the figures of a man and a woman illuminated by yellow flashlight light, and an eye appearing to look through a keyhole. The typography consists of large red letters with a white outline. The main colour palette is black and white, complemented by several accent elements: the red lettering, the woman's red dress, and the yellow light highlighting key elements of the composition.



Figure 8: Movie poster for *The Haunting* (1963)

The Haunting poster is built around a central image of a face screaming in terror. The visual uses two contrasting colours: black and turquoise. To the right of the face is a tagline that experiments with letter proportions and typographic accents. Below the main image is a graphic element resembling a labyrinth, into which the film title is integrated. The typography is elongated, with disproportionately stretched letters of different sizes.

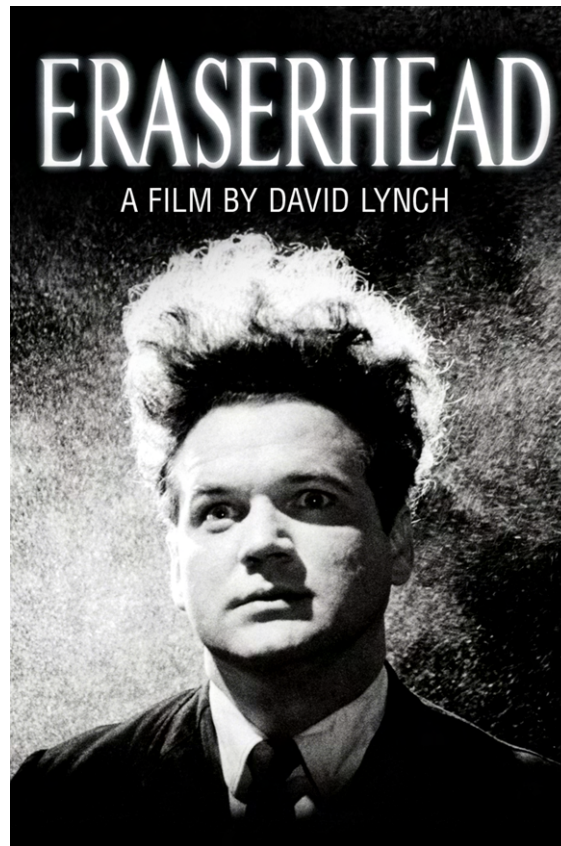


Figure 9: Movie poster for *Eraserhead* (1977)

The *Eraserhead* poster features a portrait of the main character shown in a black-and-white palette. The centre of the composition is occupied by his figure, with a distinctive voluminous hairstyle lit from behind. His face is marked by bulging eyes and deep, high-contrast shadows that intensify the unsettling impression. The background is plain, with no additional visual elements. The typography is minimalist, with letters that have a slight glowing effect.



Figure 10: Movie poster for *Halloween* (1978)

The *Halloween* slasher poster presents a veined hand holding a knife. No other elements appear in the frame — the viewer sees only the hand with the weapon and the repeated shape of the blade, which creates a recognisable graphic silhouette of a Halloween pumpkin with carved, glowing eyes. The contrasting black background highlights the objects rendered in shades of orange and red, enhancing their visual impact. The minimalist typography with the name of the movie is placed at the top of the poster.



Figure 11: Movie poster for *The Thing* (1982)

The poster for *The Thing* (1982) depicts a figure dressed in winter clothing, with the face completely concealed. Instead of facial features, a bright burst of light occupies the head area, with rays extending diagonally outward from the centre. The figure is set on a background in cold blue tones with forms that resemble ice crystals. The title is executed in large and geometric characters.

The success of *A Nightmare on Elm Street* had a notable impact on audiences and the film industry itself: New Line Cinema, an independent and relatively unknown studio at the time, became successful in the market mostly because of the franchise (McKenna & Proctor, 2022).



Figure 12: Movie posters for *A Nightmare on Elm Street* (1984), *A Nightmare on Elm Street 2: Freddy's Revenge* (1985), *A Nightmare on Elm Street 3: Dream Warriors* (1987), *A Nightmare on Elm Street 4: The Dream Master* (1988)

Regarding visual design, the posters for the first four films already demonstrate visual consistency. The recognizable style of the brand is maintained— it's clear right away that all the films are part of the same universe. The logo remains the same: it appears scratched, bloody and instantly signals the horror genre. The central character, Freddy Krueger,

appears on each poster, and with each new movie from the franchise, his image becomes more prominent and instantly recognizable. He evolves into the "face" of the franchise, with his signature glove featuring blades consistently integrated into the composition. The creators effectively capture the atmosphere of dreams. This is shown through visual elements like dim lighting, dark interiors, and bedrooms, all creating a feeling of anxiety and unease.



Figure 13: Movie poster for *The Blair Witch Project* (1999)

The promotional poster for *The Blair Witch Project* (1999), which belongs to the found-footage subgenre, employs visual solutions associated with documentary aesthetics. The specifics of the subgenre directly influence the visual choices. Most of the poster is occupied by a close-up photograph of a woman's face, captured from a low angle. A flashlight appears to shine on her face. She is wearing a winter hat, and her facial expression appears tense. In the background, a forest with darkened tree silhouettes is visible. The overall image is presented in greyish-blue tones. A small red human-shaped symbol serves as a colour accent and refers to the film's narrative.

The early 2000s and technological changes brought a new approach to horror film branding. Posters became more photographic and often minimalist in composition, focusing on one expressive object or visual motif that attracts the viewer's attention.



Figure 14: Movie poster for *The Devil's Backbone* (2001)

The *Devil's Backbone* (2001) poster is built on a strong contrast between yellow and blue colours. At the centre of the composition is the figure of a child in the foreground, while in the background a window emits intense yellow light. A mysterious silhouette is visible beyond the window. The contrast between the cold blue and the vivid yellow directs the viewer's attention and establishes a clear visual hierarchy, highlighting the main elements of the composition. The typography is presented in letters with a metallic effect.

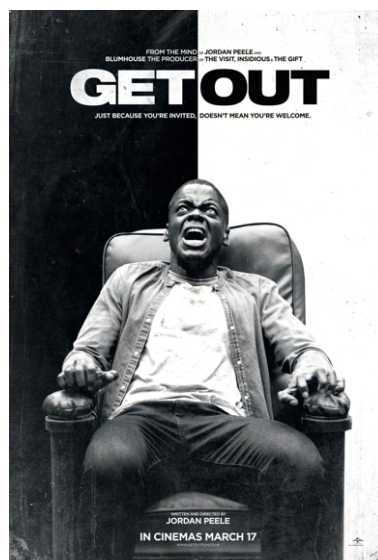


Figure 15: Movie poster for *Get Out* (2017)

The *Get Out* (2017) poster is built around a central image of a man sitting in a chair and looking upward with terror in his eyes and on his face. The context of the situation he is in is not presented to the viewer. The composition contains no extra elements, keeping all attention on the protagonist. The poster is executed in a high-contrast black-and-white

palette. The typography is placed at the top of the composition and consists of large white and black letters with clear geometric forms, arranged against a contrasting background. As a result, the film title stands out within the composition and becomes an important visual accent.

Although the posters come from different decades and styles, the analysis of titles selected from the Variety list *The 100 Best Horror Movies of All Time* reveals a series of recurring visual characteristics typical of the horror genre. Early posters relied on exaggerated forms, theatrical illustration, and dramatic scenes. Over time, posters shifted between more graphic visuals and more minimal, symbolic approaches.

Across all decades, several recurring visual elements become evident. First, horror posters consistently centre around a dominant visual motif, whether a villain, a terrified victim, or a symbolic object referring to the film's story. This main element sets the emotional tone and hints at the nature of the threat. Second, typography remains an expressive tool: whether jagged, broken, smeared, minimalistic or strict, or metallic, it reinforces unease and supports the narrative mood. Third, colour plays a key role. Horror posters often use strong contrast and a mix of cold and warm tones to create tension and guide the viewer's attention. Colours like red, black, and deep blue reinforce associations with danger, fear, or the supernatural.

Another significant pattern is the frequent use of imagery related to blood and weapons, especially in films involving physical violence. Blood appears as a visual accent and a symbolic sign of danger. Weapons such as knives, claws, and sharp objects often serve as a familiar visual cue for violence.

Genre-recognizable horror poster design is built on a set of principles: a clear central motif, expressive typography, strong visual contrast, emotionally loaded colour, and recurring symbolism of blood or weapons. Together, these elements define the visual language of horror and offer a framework for designing a poster that stays recognizable to the genre while allowing personal creative input. At the same time, horror posters do not always rely on explicit imagery such as blood, monsters, or graphic violence, as noted in the theoretical part after the poster analysis. Many rely on using symbolic or minimal cues that create curiosity and unease without revealing too much.

Thus, this section concludes the analysis of the visual language of horror. The contemporary practice of adapting visual elements of a film's identity to additional branding components and physical media formats will be examined later in the A24 case study.

1.3 Italian horror, Giallo and Dario Argento

As *Suspiria* (1977) is a central focus of this thesis, it is important to outline the broader context of Italian horror and the Giallo tradition. Giallo is a genre which developed in Italy in the mid-to-late 1960s and thrived in the 1970s. Giallo films often combine detective storytelling and horror elements, featuring scenes of overt violence and bloodshed. The protagonist in such films is typically an outsider — someone who finds themselves in an unfamiliar environment. They face an impending threat but cannot convince others of its reality, as they lack social influence and power. As a result, even after the criminal or antagonist is exposed, the hero remains vulnerable to evil (Owen, 2023).

The Giallo genre can be seen as the successor to the Italian Gothic tradition, which primarily focused on the fear of external threats. However, Giallo developed in a distinct direction. While drawing on Italian Gothic imagery and thematic elements, it relocated them into a contemporary urban setting and drew attention to psychological fears relevant to twentieth-century audiences. While Italian Gothic films often focused on the past and the supernatural, Giallo engaged with personal anxieties and internal crises. This explains the frequent use of mirrors and reflections within the genre, as well as in its distinctive visual style, characterized by vivid color palettes and theatrical, often unrealistic lighting (Brown, 2012).

The Giallo genre holds a vital place in the history of world cinema, and its influence can still be seen today. A great example is the film *MaXXXine* by director Ti West, released in 2024. The film captures the atmosphere of 1980s cinema and Italian giallo through its bold use of color, lighting, and stylistic references to the genre's classic films (Dillon, 2024).

Dario Argento is one of the most important names in Italian horror and giallo. The director of *Suspiria* was born in Rome on September 7, 1940. He came into the world in a family where both parents were directly involved in art and cinema. As a child, Dario was often ill and spent much time at home, immersed in reading. He was especially impressed by the works of Edgar Allan Poe, which left a deep mark on his imagination and were later reflected in his work. Argento is often called the "Italian Hitchcock" for his ability to create an atmosphere of tension and anxiety (Gracey, 2010).

Argento's debut feature, *The Bird With the Crystal Plumage* (1970), is considered one of the best Giallo movies. The director is a master at creating a world where visuals perfectly match the plot (King, 2018). In this early film, it is already possible to identify several key elements that would later define Argento's visual style. His fascination with stylistic excess and his willingness to explore psychological labyrinths are clearly present. *The Bird With the Crystal Plumage* sets the stage for the innovative approach he would continue to develop in his later films. Dario Argento's films are truly captivating due to the unique artistic vision. His color palettes are often unnatural, his camera work features unusual angles and striking contrasts. The visual imagery in his films is memorable at first glance. Argento's cinematic world can be described as a world where logic doesn't matter. Everything appears unstable and distorted, as if turned upside down (McDonagh, 2010).

Suspiria is a film by Dario Argento, released in 1977. It tells the story of an American ballet dancer who arrives at a prestigious academy and soon realizes that the school is full of dark secrets she must uncover.

The giallo genre is characterized by the presence of a detective storyline. However, in several of Dario Argento's films, the boundary between detective fiction and the supernatural is blurred. For example, in *Deep Red*, elements of a classic giallo story are combined with supernatural motifs. This tendency is further developed in *Suspiria*, where the supernatural takes over the whole story. As a result, *Suspiria* is not usually considered a classic example of giallo, despite the fact that Argento is regarded as one of the recognized masters of the genre (Brown, 2012).

When it comes to visual style, Luciano Tovoli's cinematography in *Suspiria* (1977) defines the visual style of the Giallo tradition through high-contrast lighting and saturated colour. His use of bold hues—especially red and violet—turns the academy into a stylised, dream-like space where colour carries meaning rather than working as decoration (Pérez Valero, 2019).

In summary, *Suspiria* holds an important place in Italian horror and in twentieth-century cinema. Although it is not a traditional Giallo film, it uses many of the genre's visual and thematic elements and adapts them in its own way. In this film, Argento's use of style, colour, and psychological tension is especially distinctive. Luciano Tovoli's cinematography further strengthens its impact, creating a visual style that has influenced filmmakers and artists for decades. For these reasons, *Suspiria* is regarded as a key work of Italian horror and a significant reference for horror aesthetics.

1.4 Merch as a Branding Tool: A24 Case Study

Merchandise has become a notable element of contemporary film branding, especially in genres that rely on strong visual symbolism, such as horror. The strategies employed by studio A24 illustrate how merchandise can operate as an extension of a film's branding, particularly when it takes unconventional forms. Examining A24's approach therefore provides a useful context for understanding the decision to explore more unusual types of merchandise within this thesis.

Speaking of A24, what started as a small independent distributor has developed into a globally recognised cultural phenomenon with many successful and Oscar-winning films (Chmielewski, 2023). Focusing on A24 is particularly relevant to this thesis because, while the company produces films across various genres, it is primarily recognized for its horror films. A24 became internationally known for shaping the post-horror trend, with films like *The Witch* and *Midsommar* that blend sincerity and irony in a metamodern style (Simms, 2024).

The story of A24 began in 2012 when three people from the movie industry, David Fenkel, Daniel Katz and John Hodges, came together with the vision of creating a film distribution studio. Creators believed that the industry, dominated by massive companies, often limited creatives and prevented filmmakers from fully expressing their artistic potential (Singh, n.d.). Granting creators more control over their work is often associated with higher risks regarding a film's commercial success. This is why Fenkel, Katz, and Hodges cut marketing costs by avoiding traditional marketing methods like print ads and Super Bowl commercials. While being less expensive, these methods can still be highly effective, as proven by the case of A24 and their successful projects (Sanders, 2022).

One of the most striking and well-known examples of A24's creative approach is what they did for the film *Ex Machina*. The company created a fake Tinder profile for the film's main character, which redirected those who swiped on it to the movie's official Instagram page (Rose, 2021). A24's films not only create a loyal fan base but also prove to be quite successful commercially. A24 is a master at turning films into events, effectively attracting viewers to theaters even for unconventional, niche projects (Hayes & Gawaran, 2024).

Merchandise in the film industry is typically associated with standard items such as T-shirts or caps. However, A24 offers a considerably broader and more unconventional selection of products on its official website. The website's navigation is divided into distinct categories, and in the *Goods* section, one can find candles, car air fresheners, mugs, trays, notepads, soap, and even beach towels. Many of these items appear intentionally absurd, and the longer one looks, the more it becomes clear that this is the point. A24 draws attention through its ironic and playful approach to branding. The studio isn't afraid to seem playful, and since it has many successful and award-winning projects, this makes its visual and brand style even more impressive.

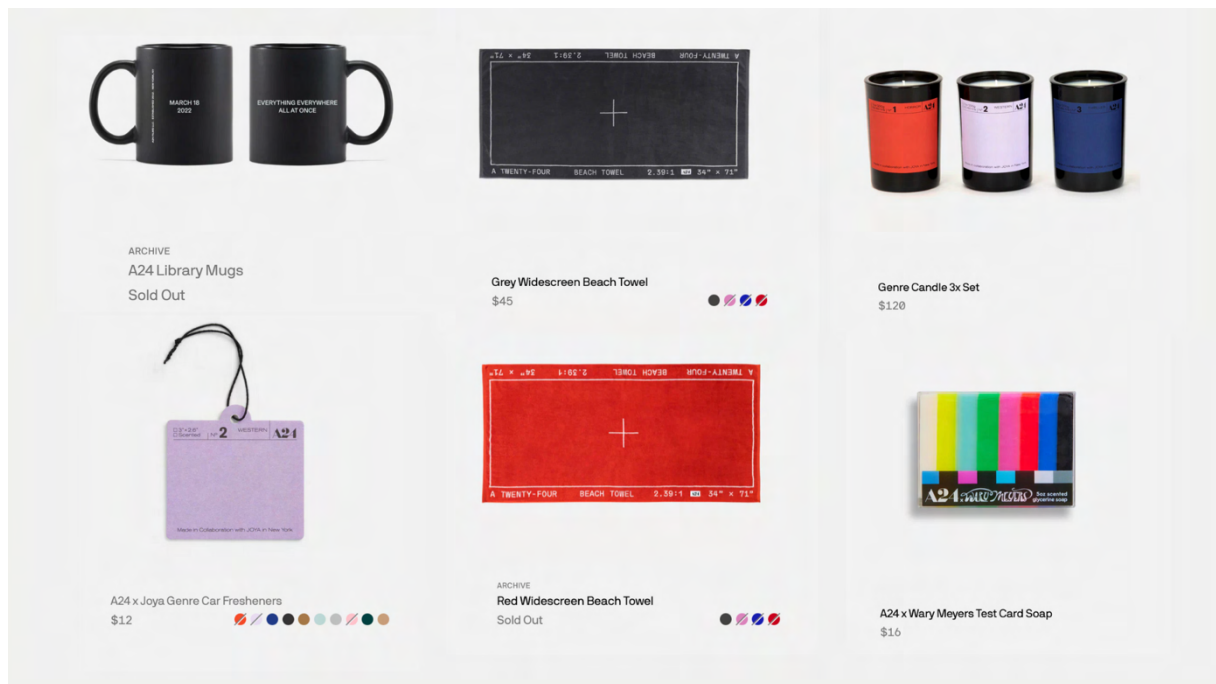


Figure 16: A24 Shop

The studio also produces merchandise directly tied to specific films, including items featured in particular scenes or clothing worn by characters. This way, A24 not only becomes a brand itself, but each film becomes a recognizable brand. The studio does this purposefully, treating every project as an individual work with both creative and commercial potential. In each movie, A24 finds a unique detail to highlight—and it's not always something obvious. At times, these are entirely unexpected elements that, within the context of the film, take on special meaning and become highly desirable to fans. Bartak (2022) notes that A24 operates an online merch shop that provides a small but intentional source of revenue. This indicates that merchandise is part of the studio's broader strategy. The studio's unusual and often playful merchandise can be understood as an extension of its overall brand identity, as well as the individual identities of its films. These products function not only as commercial items but also help build a sense of community around A24 and reinforce its image as a distinctive and culturally aware film studio.

A24 allows its fans to connect with the world of indie cinema and particular characters by offering a wide range of merchandise. A24 produces not only T-shirts in collaboration with brands like Supreme and Burberry but also releases more distinctive and, at times, provocative items. For instance, the company sold latex gloves with hot dog fingers in connection with *Everything Everywhere All at Once*. To accompany *Beau Is Afraid*, A24 offered a themed pajama set aimed at dedicated fans (Mac Donnel, 2024).

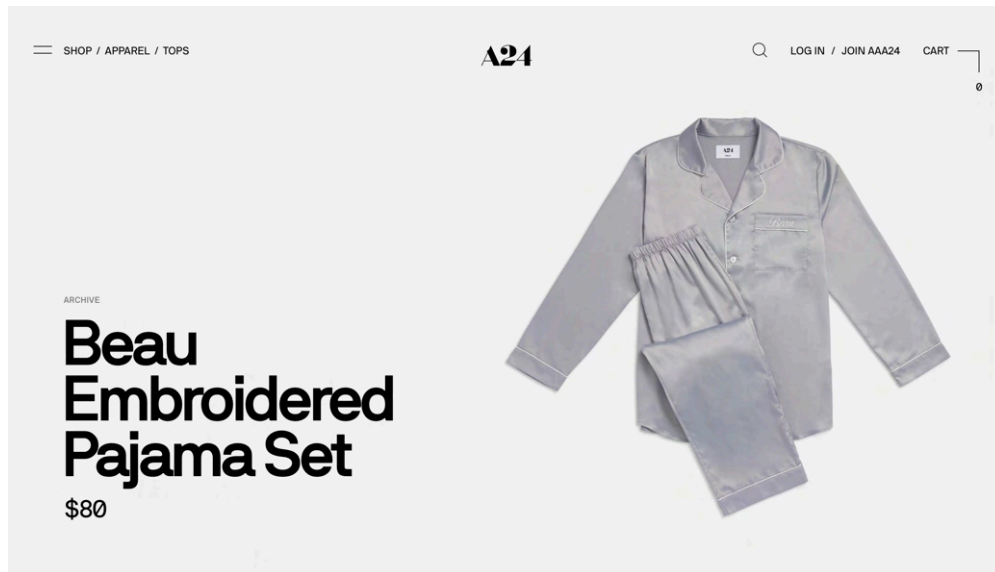


Figure 17: A24 Pajama Set

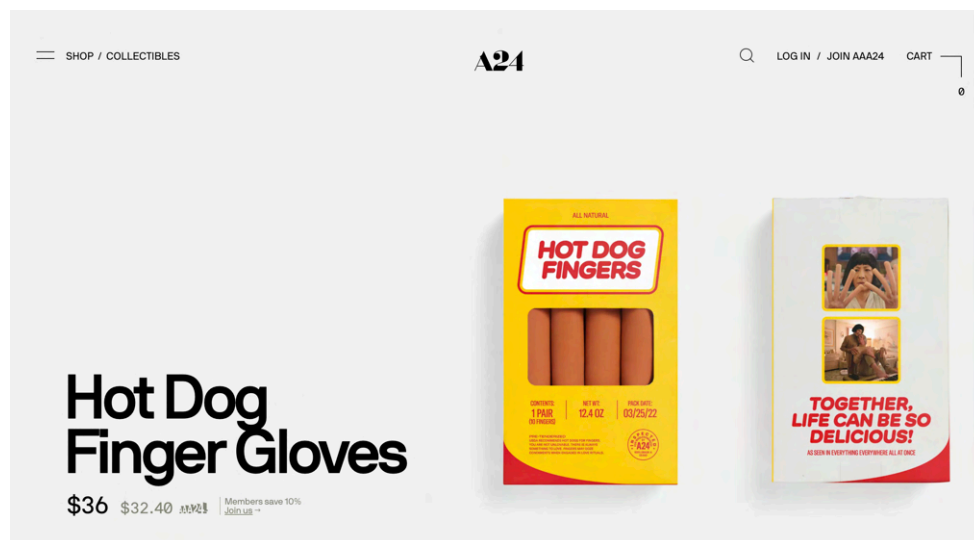


Figure 18: A24 Hot Dog Finger Gloves

It is also important to note that some A24-branded T-shirts, which were originally sold at relatively low prices, are later resold for several hundred dollars. A lot of the shirts with A24 movie graphics were probably made for the price of a regular t-shirt but they can be resold online for over \$200 on Grailed, and hoodies can hit \$500 (Freeman, 2021). This indicates that the studio's merchandise is seen not as clothing but as a cultural object—a collectible artifact. The increase in resale value reflects the strength and cultural resonance of A24's visual brand. It shows that people are attracted to the idea of belonging to this world and are eager to own something rare and symbolically meaningful.

Particular attention was paid to the *Collectibles* section of A24's official website, as its structure and content are directly relevant to the practical part of this thesis. It offers exclusive items aimed at collectors: Blu-ray editions of the studio's films, various toys, posters, and vinyl records featuring soundtracks—all presented with a high level of attention to detail. However, even here, A24 goes beyond simply offering a well-designed box and a

disc with deleted scenes. Some editions include special materials such as behind-the-scenes photo cards and posters. For instance, the collector's Blu-ray box for *The Lighthouse* includes storyboards, on-set photographs, and production design sketches. These extras are not just bonuses—they help the viewer stay connected to the film.

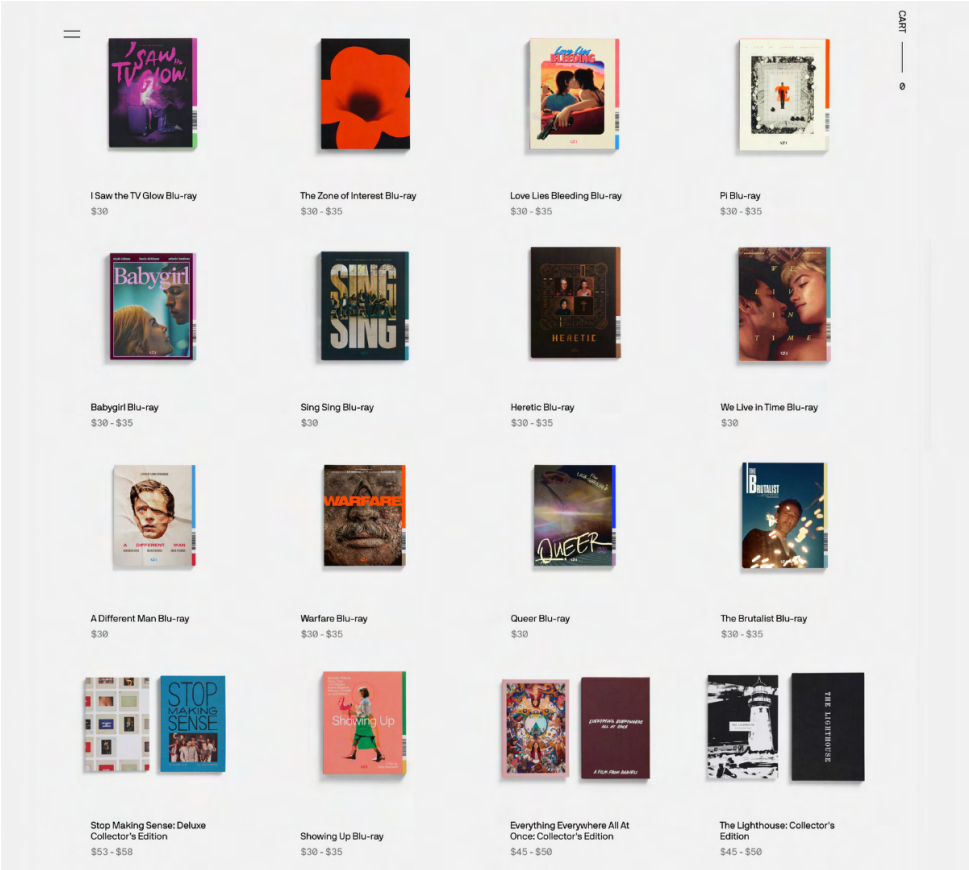


Figure 19: A24 Blu-rays

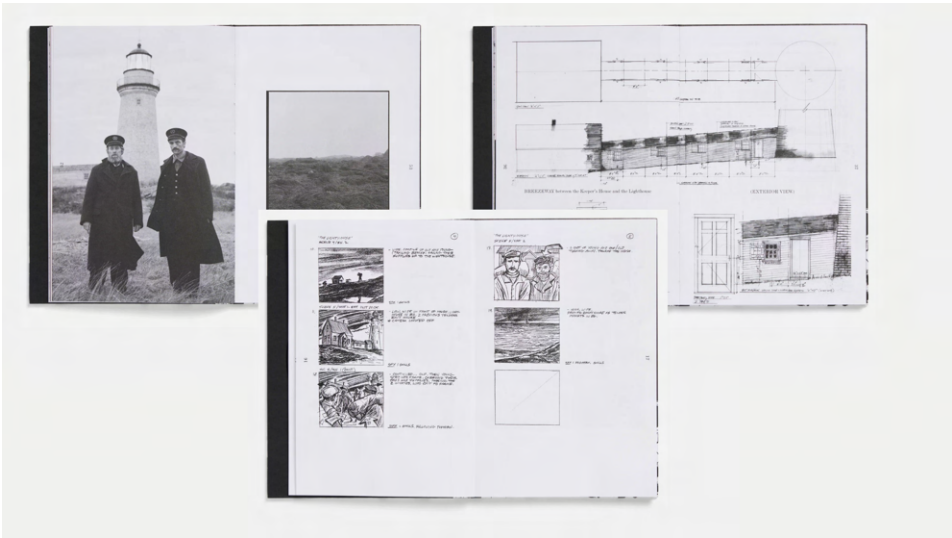


Figure 20: A24 Lighthouse Blu-ray

The analysis shows that A24 treats merchandise as an extension of both its studio brand and the aesthetic identity of individual films, thereby strengthening the connection between audiences. This approach shows that unconventional merchandise can be an effective way to support a brand. Findings from the A24 case study therefore provide the theoretical basis for developing distinctive merchandise concepts in the practical section of this thesis.

2 Practical part

The practical part of this thesis applies the findings made in the theoretical part of the thesis to the creation of a new visual branding proposal for the film *Suspiria* (1977). The practical part continues the central aim of the thesis: to create modern branding for *Suspiria* that ensures genre recognisability while remaining visually appealing to contemporary audiences.

The choice of *Suspiria* for this project is based on both its artistic qualities and the author's long-term interest in visual communication within the horror genre. *Suspiria* is a film in which stylistic expression plays a central narrative role, particularly through its saturated colours and theatrical lighting. At the same time, unlike widely recognised Hollywood franchises, *Suspiria* lacks a fully developed contemporary branding presence across merchandise and related media. This mix of strong visual potential and minimal existing branding makes the film well suited for a redesign.

The practical part outlines the entire design process—from initial visual research and the development of mood boards to sketching and exploring alternative concepts. It then presents the final poster and explains the key design decisions related to motif, colour, typography, texture, and composition, as well as their application to the Blu-ray and vinyl formats. The chapter also provides an overview of an online survey conducted to assess whether the new branding communicates the horror genre effectively, appeals to contemporary viewers, and remains coherent across all designed materials.

2.1 Pre-production of redesign

The pre-production stage was necessary for collecting references, creating mood boards, and planning to develop the poster and additional materials. At this stage, it was important to consider what the final product should be to meet the set goals: convey the atmosphere of the film and simultaneously appeal to both loyal fans and new viewers. Before the production phase began, it became clear that it would be important to remain open to experimentation and to be ready to abandon several ideas to find a precise and expressive concept.

2.1.1 Visual research and mood boards creation

Before beginning the design process, it was necessary to analyse the existing poster for *Suspiria* in order to develop a distinctive and original concept. Several mood boards were then created to explore visual directions that aligned with the author's aesthetic preferences. While working on these mood boards, the aim was to brainstorm ideas not directly related to cinema or existing poster designs, and to develop several stylistic approaches that could be pursued further. At the same time, it was important to consider how the visual elements identified in the theoretical part—such as a clear central motif, expressive typography, strong contrast, emotionally charged colour, and symbolic rather than explicit cues of horror—could be integrated into the new design. These principles helped ensure that the poster remained recognisable as part of the horror genre while still allowing room for personal creative interpretation.

Visual research is crucial as designers need to understand the visual styles and messages that already exist in the world where their designs will appear. People have certain expectations when they look at visual content. Good design connects with these familiar styles and adds something new and exciting to them (Noble & Bestley, 2005).

The 1977 original poster is an example of a minimalist but very expressive image. In the center of the composition is the silhouette of a dancer with bright red blood flowing down her body. The entire work is built on only three colors: black, white, and red. This color scheme conveys emotions of horror to the viewer and, of course, attracts attention.

The font plays a special role here. The deformed letters create a feeling of instability and uncertainty, which enhances the overall impression of anxiety.

The 1977 poster does not try to attract attention with cheap tricks - it does not shout at the viewer, but on the contrary, it acts subtly and delicately. And this is where its expressiveness and strength lie.



Figure 21: Movie poster for *Suspiria* (1977)

For the first mood board, a collage style inspired by Dadaist aesthetics was chosen. Dada collages often combine unsettling visual elements such as distorted faces with layered textures, evoking feelings of disorientation and even discomfort in viewers (Cramer & Grant, n.d.). This aesthetic supports the theme of the human identity crisis explored in the film *Suspiria*.

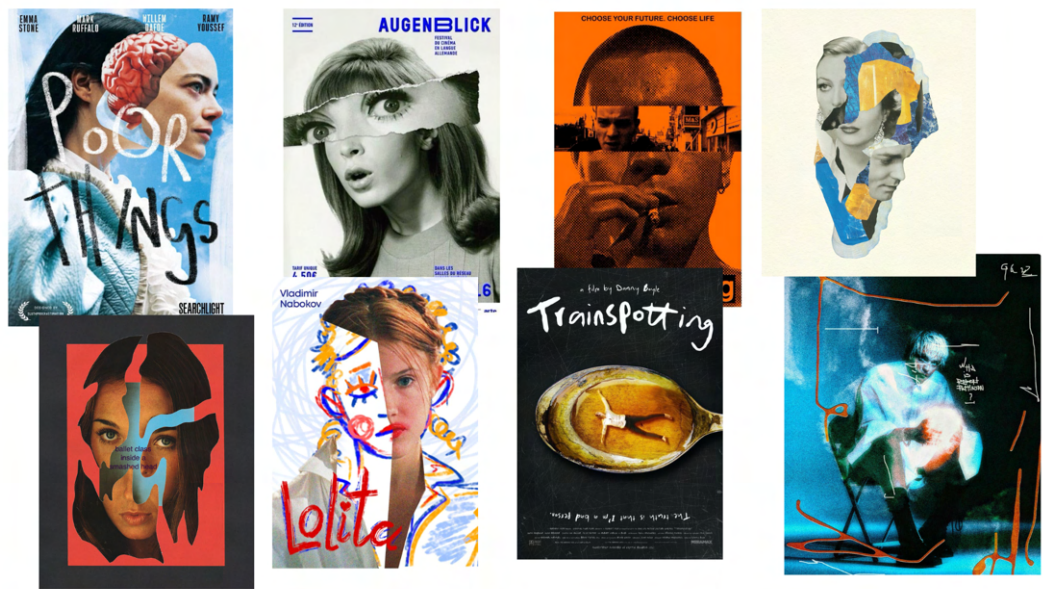


Figure 22: Mood board 1

The second mood board took on a more minimalistic approach, focusing on the use of color, silhouettes, contrast, and visual metaphors.



more minimalistic

Figure 23: Mood board 2

The third mood board was created with a focus on typography and the use of text. These images are limited to two or three colors. Letters become an integral part of the narrative. Typography carries the concept in these images: the letters are not just decorative elements supporting the visuals but stand-alone visual elements that express the main idea.



Figure 24: Mood board 3

After working on all the mood boards, it became clear that it is important to try different approaches—sketching by hand, experimenting with a graphics editor, and exploring which direction resonates most with the intended aesthetic of the project. This process helps identify a visual style that suits the aims of the project and provides a strong source of creative inspiration.

2.1.2 Sketches and alternative concepts

The approach was to design the poster as the central visual element, which would serve as the foundation for the additional materials. Initially, several directions were considered, but a different path was ultimately chosen.

The process began with sketching on paper, as this method felt more natural and provided greater creative freedom while reducing the fear of making mistakes. In fact, many designers choose to sketch by hand before switching to design software. Graphic designer Steff Geissbuhler discusses this approach in *How to Think Like a Great Graphic Designer* by Debbie Millman. When asked whether he primarily works by hand or on the computer, he responded: „Both. A lot of sketching happens away from the computer, in sketchbooks, on snips of paper, the backs of envelopes, etc. The computer then becomes a production tool, where alternative versions can be quickly generated and variations can be explored“ (2007, p.185).

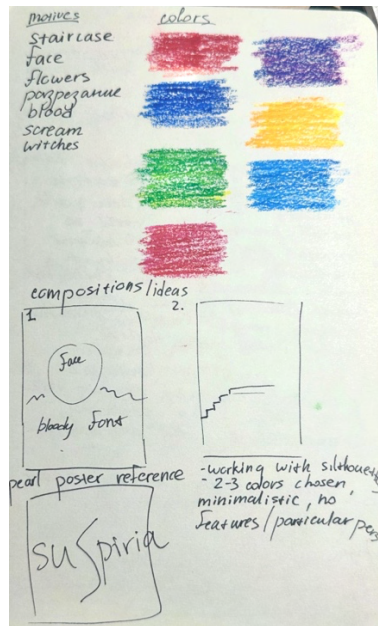


Figure 25: The author's sketches 1

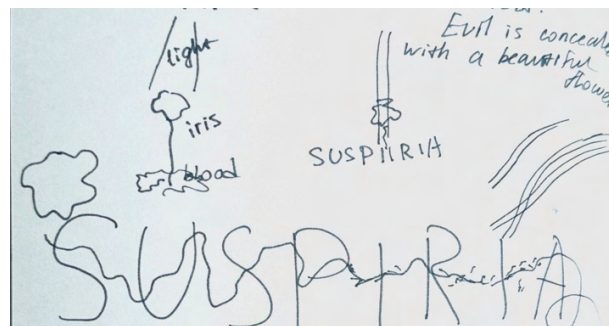


Figure 26: The author's sketches 2

One of the explored options was a retro-inspired poster featuring one of the film's most iconic scenes. Various textures and interior elements from the film were integrated into the design to make the poster distinctive. Since the colour palette in *Suspiria* is highly recognisable, the author worked with the shades that appear most frequently in the film's key moments.



Figure 27: Concept 1

Regarding typography, a subtle, unobtrusive typeface was chosen to keep the viewer's attention on the visual motifs.

Subsequently, it was decided to explore a more minimalist approach: a monochromatic background and silhouettes of motifs appearing in the film's narrative—the dancer, the knife, and the blue iris flower, which plays a significant role in the movie. The background consisted of a red texture, evoking a retro atmosphere.



Figure 28: Concept 2

After consulting the initial design variations with the thesis supervisor, it became clear that the first proposed posters did not offer the desired level of originality, as the widely recognisable image of the main character has already been extensively used in existing promotional materials. The intention behind the redesign was to create a visual identity that would offer a fresh and distinctive perspective on Dario Argento's film. During these consultations, the early concepts were further assessed, and it was agreed that they did not yet achieve sufficient visual coherence. It became clear that the film title did not work well with the other elements: the typography felt separate, and the graphic parts did not come together as a cohesive whole.

The intention was to create the poster to appear more cohesive and to evoke conflicting emotions, engaging the viewer's interest. To achieve this, it was necessary to move away from the more conventional and overused horror motifs (e.g., a girl in danger or a knife), which often appear in genre posters. While such imagery can be visually effective, it was not considered suitable for *Suspiria* by the author of the thesis, whose aim was to create a visually distinct concept. Instead, the intention was to use genre-associated elements more selectively and in a way that supports the film's specific atmosphere rather than repeating familiar tropes.

2.2 Production

After the pre-production phase, the author concluded that it was important to move toward visual and compositional simplification without sacrificing the depth and semantic richness of the project. The decision to move away from more visually dense drafts was guided by a phenomenon in visual arts known as *horror vacui*, as described in the book *Universal Principles of Design* by Lidwell, Holden, and Butler (2010). *Horror vacui* in the design context is a fear of empty space, which results in adding unnecessary details. A minimalist approach in designing the new poster and associated merchandise for the cult classic *Suspiria* proved to be more effective, as contemporary audiences frequently associate minimalist design with exclusivity and prestige (2010, p. 128).

To allow more negative space and achieve balance, the author chose to rely on key visual elements that could serve as starting points for further design exploration. These elements needed to be meaningful, recognizable, and capable of conveying the core ideas embedded in the project without overwhelming the viewer.

Thus, the decision was made to develop a poster that conveys the film's atmosphere through symbolism, using subtle and unobtrusive hints. The aim was not to intimidate the viewer directly but to evoke a sense of threat concealed beneath a surface of beauty and visual allure. At the initial stage, motifs that were less conventional yet integral to the narrative were considered, focusing on those that could be organically integrated into both the poster and the merchandise elements.

The blue iris flower was chosen as the central motif. This element is crucial in the film's plot and symbolizes beauty and sophistication. Throughout the film, the protagonist, Suzy, repeatedly hears references to the blue iris from another character, yet she does not realize what they mean. Ultimately, it is revealed that the blue flower on one of the academy's walls functions as a hidden mechanism that opens a secret passage leading to concealed rooms

within the dance academy. The blue iris symbolizes a pivotal plot twist and the unveiling of sinister secrets, and it is a well-known motif among film fans.

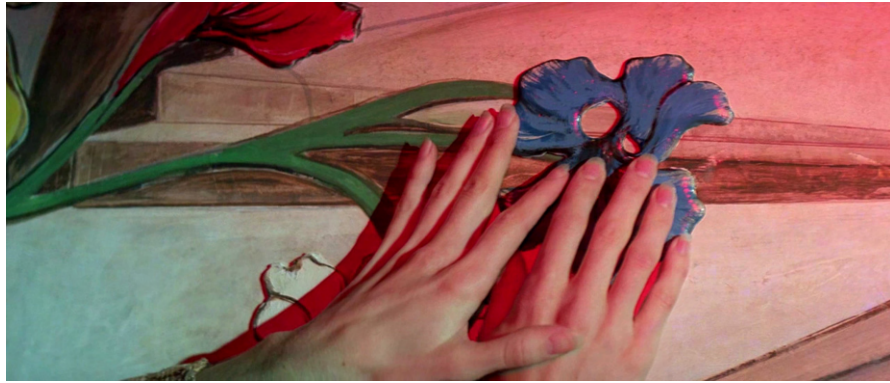


Figure 29: Scene from *Suspiria* (dir. Dario Argento, 1977)

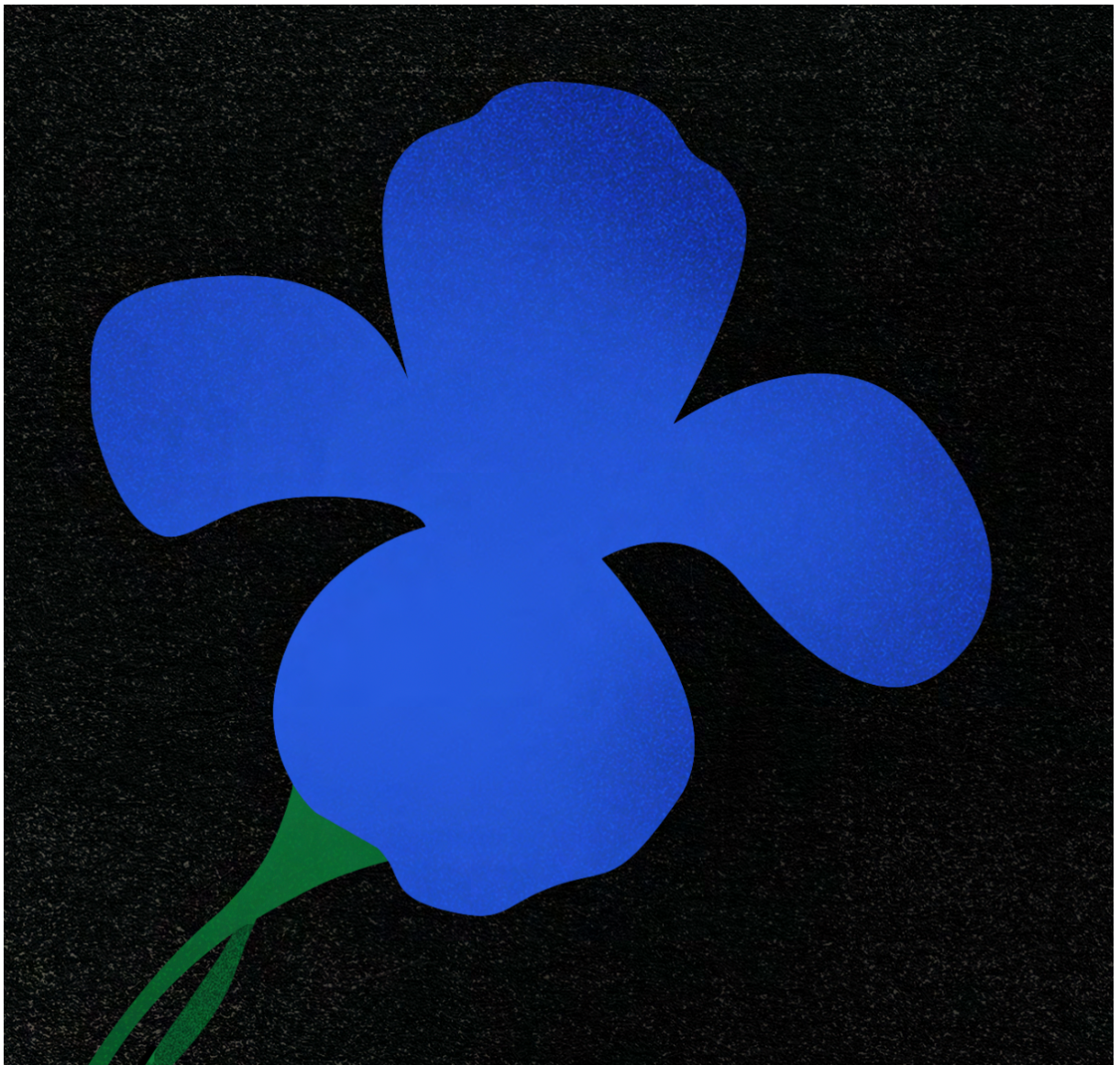


Figure 30: Poster detail

To convey the duality of the film's world—where horrors unfold within visually enchanting surroundings—a metaphor was developed: the green stems of the iris gradually transform into barbed wire, from which drops of blood subtly drip, marking the final stage of the metamorphosis. Thus, this reinforces the viewer's sense of unease. In this context, the barbed wire symbolizes the mortal danger concealed beneath the beautiful exterior. Barbed wire plays a significant role in one of the film's scenes: one of the female characters becomes trapped in a room filled with wire and dies, unable to escape.

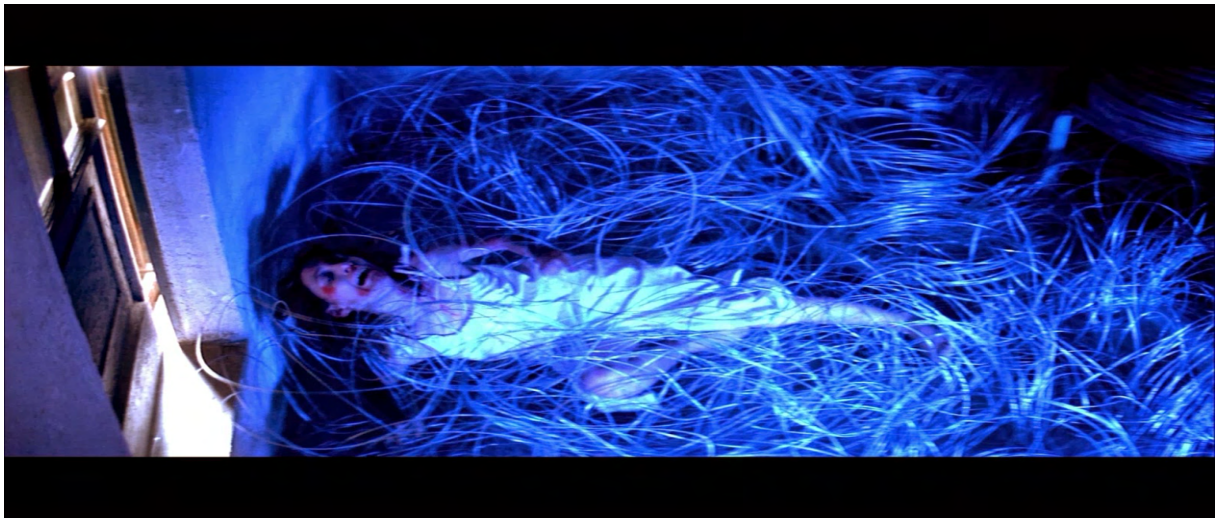


Figure 31: Scene from *Suspiria* (dir. Dario Argento, 1977)

The discussion returns to the previously mentioned book *Universal Principles of Design* and the concept of propositional density, which is described as a key factor in making designs appealing and memorable to viewers. Propositional density can be simply explained as the amount of meaning that is carried by an image. According to this principle, simple visual elements containing multiple layers of meaning tend to resonate more strongly with viewers than visually overloaded compositions with weak content (Lidwell, Holden & Butler, 2010, p. 190). In this work, significant meaning was embedded within a simple form—a flower and its stems—which symbolise concealed danger beneath something visually appealing and beautiful.



Figure 32: Poster detail 2

Special attention was paid to the choice of typeface. While there are no strict rules for using a particular font in design, the selection largely depends on context, specific circumstances, and the primary aim the designer wants to achieve (Lupton, 2010).

The font chosen was Dunbar Low Bold, as it could be successfully integrated into the design without distracting from the main visual elements—the iris flower and barbed stems, which are wrapped around the letters. Instead, it helps balance the composition and adds a modern tone to the design. Like other geometric sans-serif typefaces such as the prototypical Futura, Dunbar Low Bold is clean and confident. Typefaces have their own personalities based on shape, contrast, and historical context, and in this case, the typography is used not to overpower the imagery but to complement it (Coles, 2012). A combination of Dunbar Low Regular and Dunbar Low Light was used for the director's name.



Figure 33: Poster typography

Suspiria is widely recognized for its expressive and highly stylized color palette. The film's cinematography is far from accidental; the director, Dario Argento, and cinematographer, Luciano Tovoli, employed saturated colors as a tool of artistic expression. In an interview, Luciano Tovoli stated: "I decided to intensively utilize primary colors—blue, green and red—to identify the normal flow of life, and then apply a complementary color, mainly yellow, to contaminate them" (2018, Williams).

This visual strategy became a central influence in the poster design. It was important to develop a color palette that captures *Suspiria's* unsettling, almost hallucinatory atmosphere. Through the use of color, the filmmakers signal that what is on screen exists outside of everyday reality. Vivid, provocative tones draw the viewer in and immerse them in a world where beauty and horror coexist.

While watching the film, screenshots were taken and a selection of frames was compiled to analyse which colours appeared most frequently. Based on this analysis, a custom colour palette was created for the poster, incorporating blue, green, and bright red, which, as established in the theoretical part, are strongly associated with the visual language of the horror genre. The goal was to preserve the atmosphere of *Suspiria* while expressing it through the author's artistic vision.

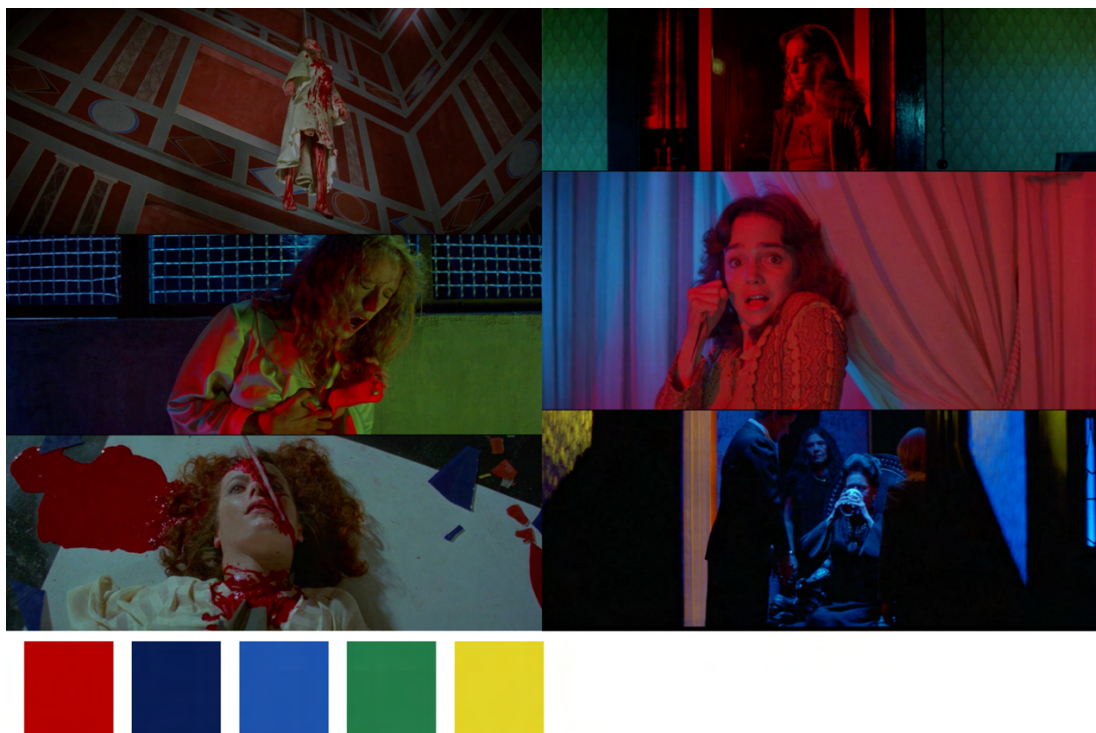


Figure 34: Color palette of *Suspiria* (1977)



Figure 35: Poster

Since the design is done in a fairly simple and 2D style, it felt necessary to give it more expressiveness to look better on paper and printed products. A grain texture was applied to the flowers, stems, and dark background to avoid overloading the design with unnecessary details. This was done to avoid making the image look flat or lifeless. Additionally, the grain added a touch of retro style that contributed to an atmosphere aligned with the aesthetic

and mood of *Suspiria*. The authors of the book *Graphic Design: The New Basics* discuss the importance of texture in shaping the viewer's perception of design, noting that "many of the textures that designers manipulate are not physically experienced by the viewer at all, but exist as optical effect and representation. Texture adds detail to an image, providing an overall surface quality as well as rewarding the eye when viewed up close" (Lupton & Cole, 2015, p. 145).



Figure 36: Poster grain

2.2.1 Production of additional materials

Inspired by A24's creative approach, a Blu-ray Collector's Edition was designed for this film. The design includes not only the cover and the disc but also a set of cards featuring behind-the-scenes photographs, enhancing the viewer's emotional connection to the film.

The central visual motif of the redesign is the blue iris, which was placed inside the box beneath the disc. The disc is designed in a minimalist style, featuring a deep blue background and a simple *Suspiria* title. This approach was chosen to prevent visual overload and draw attention to the accompanying elements—the collector's cards and the packaging design.



Figure 37: Blu-Ray



Figure 38: Blu-Ray 2

As a second product, a design for a vinyl record was created. This choice was influenced by the growing popularity of analog media, particularly vinyl, which has been experiencing a notable revival. A new generation of listeners is returning to physical formats, viewing listening as a kind of ritual. Unlike digital playback, which often requires only the press of a button, playing a vinyl record takes more effort: preparing the turntable, selecting a record, and carefully cleaning it to remove dust. This tactile interaction offers a rare sensory experience in today's digital era (Guo, 2023).

Moreover, one of the key elements of the movie *Suspiria*, and arguably a significant factor in its lasting success, is its soundtrack, composed by the Italian progressive rock band *Goblin*. The band succeeded at creating an unsettling atmosphere throughout the film. Even today, the soundtrack remains strikingly fresh and original. It complements the film's visual language perfectly, intensifying the sense of anxiety. For this reason, designing a vinyl edition with the film's soundtrack and its packaging was considered particularly fitting. (Nissan, 2017).

In the design of the vinyl packaging, expressive accents were used—specifically red and blue colours. The vinyl itself is made in a non-standard, colored version, which gives it the character of an exclusive collector's edition.



Figure 39: Vinyl



Figure 40: Vinyl 2

2.3 Survey

To evaluate the perception of the newly designed poster and merchandise for the film *Suspiria* (1977), a quantitative perception-based survey was conducted as part of the practical component of this bachelor's thesis. Its aim was to determine how visually appealing contemporary audiences find the design, whether they clearly identify its genre cues, and whether they recognise it as a horror film. Additionally, the survey examined whether the visual style remains consistent when the poster design is applied to Blu-ray and vinyl covers. Data collection took place in December 2024 and produced 44 complete responses. The anonymous questionnaire was created using Google Forms and distributed through social media and student groups. This approach made it possible to reach respondents with varying levels of interest in the horror genre. The full questionnaire is included in the appendix of this thesis.

The survey employed an adaptive structure: the introductory question “How familiar are you with the film *Suspiria* (1977)?” directed respondents to different follow-up sections depending on their level of prior knowledge. This ensured that each participant evaluated only the elements relevant to their experience.

Most respondents were unfamiliar with the *Suspiria* film, which enabled them to evaluate the poster with a fresh first impression. Thirty-two participants (72.7%) had neither seen the film nor knew anything about it. Another nine respondents (20.5%) indicated that they had heard of the film but were not familiar with its genre. Only one person (2.3%) reported knowing the genre without having seen the film, and two more respondents (4.5%) had seen *Suspiria* and remembered its genre.

How familiar are you with the film *Suspiria* (1977)?

44 ответа

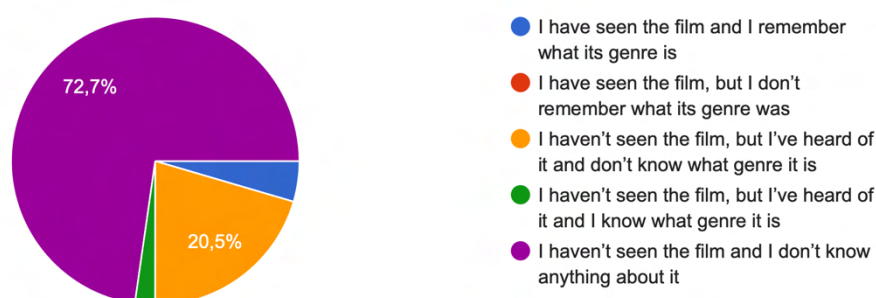


Figure 41: Results of a survey 1

Thus, 41 out of 44 participants (93.2%) assessed the poster without relying on prior knowledge of the film. This is important because it allows the analysis to show how well the new design communicates the film's genre. In addition, the structure of the questionnaire was adaptive: depending on how respondents answered this first question, they were directed to different follow-up sections. This branching ensured that each participant received questions appropriate to their level of familiarity with the film.

2.3.1 Demographic Profile of Respondents and Attitudes Toward Horror

The survey included participants from two age groups: respondents aged 18–24 made up 18 individuals (40.9%), while the 25–34 group included 26 individuals (59.1%).

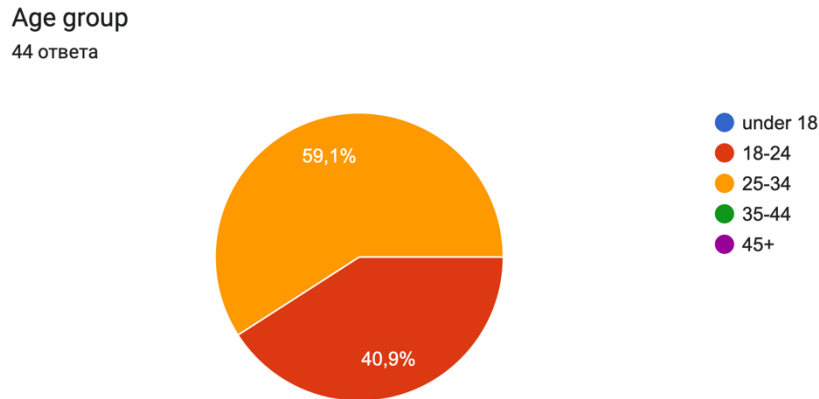


Figure 42: Results of a survey 2

Alongside demographic information, the questionnaire included a question about respondents' attitudes toward the horror genre. It is important to note that the question regarding respondents' attitudes toward the horror genre was intentionally placed at the very end of the questionnaire. This structure prevented participants from assuming in advance that the survey was specifically related to horror films, which could have influenced their interpretation of the poster. Respondents assessed the genre and visuals without knowing until the end that the poster was for a horror film.

The responses showed different attitudes toward horror films. Twenty-one respondents (47.7%) reported that they do not particularly enjoy the genre, eleven respondents (25.0%) generally like it, eight participants (18.2%) stated that they greatly enjoy horror, and four respondents (9.1%) expressed a negative attitude toward it.

Thus, more than half of the sample consists of individuals who feel neutral or negative toward horror films. The poster and its genre affiliation were evaluated primarily by viewers who are not fans of the genre.

Do you like horror films?
44 ответа

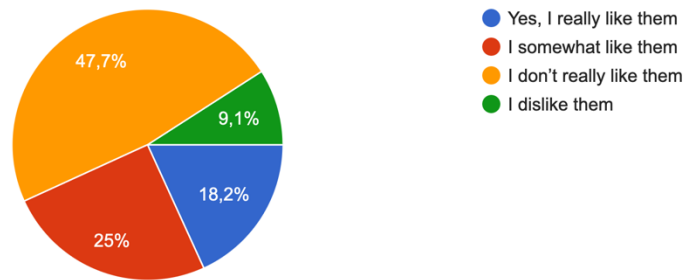


Figure 43: Results of a survey 3

2.3.2 Evaluation of the Poster's Visual Qualities

To determine how visually appealing the poster is to a contemporary audience, the survey included questions aimed at assessing key aspects of its visual qualities. Each question was based on a six-point Likert scale, where 1 represented the most negative evaluation and 6 the most positive. The questions were designed to measure how respondents perceived the poster in terms of attractiveness, its modern look, how well the colours work together, and its ability to create interest in the film.

The first question ("How attractive does this poster look to you?") asked respondents to evaluate the visual appeal of the poster, where 1 meant "Not attractive at all" and 6 meant "Very attractive." The question "How up-to-date and contemporary does this poster look to you?" addressed the perceived modernity of the graphic style; in this case, 1 corresponded to "Very outdated and irrelevant," while 6 corresponded to "Very modern and in line with current design trends." The third question ("Do the colours on this poster look good together?") focused on the colour palette, with 1 meaning "Not good at all" and 6 meaning "Very good." Finally, the fourth question ("If you saw this poster somewhere, for example online or in a cinema, how would it affect your interest in the film?") assessed whether the poster would create interest in the film. In this case, 1 indicated "I definitely would not be interested in finding out more about the film," while 6 indicated "I definitely would be interested in finding out more about the film."

The evaluation of visual attractiveness showed that most respondents perceived the poster positively. The average score was 3.82, and the median score was 4, indicating generally favourable impressions without extremely high evaluations.

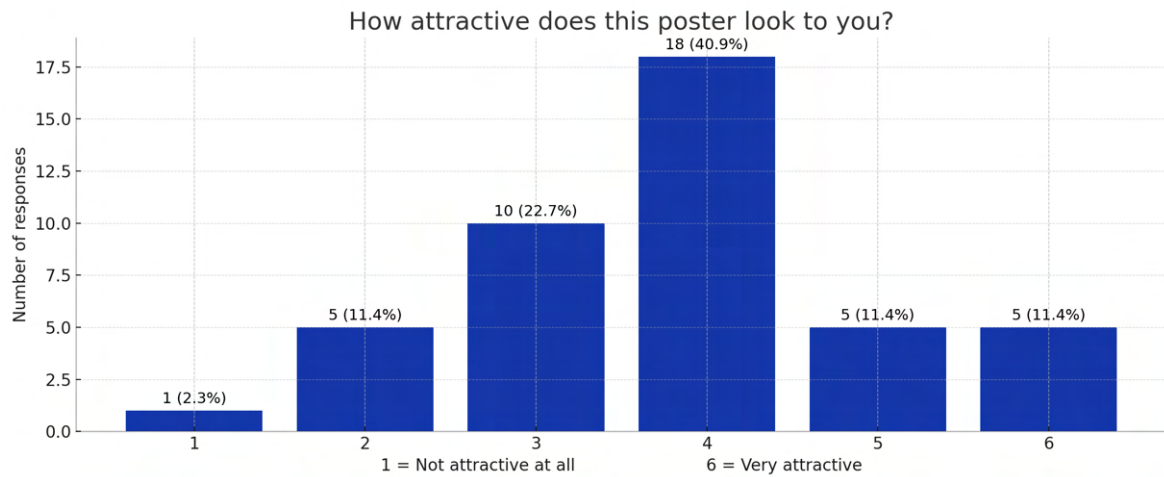


Figure 44: Results of a survey 4

The perceived modernity of the poster's graphic language received an average score of 3.95, with a median of 4. The responses ranged from 2 to 6, meaning that most respondents saw the poster as contemporary, but some viewed it as more traditional.

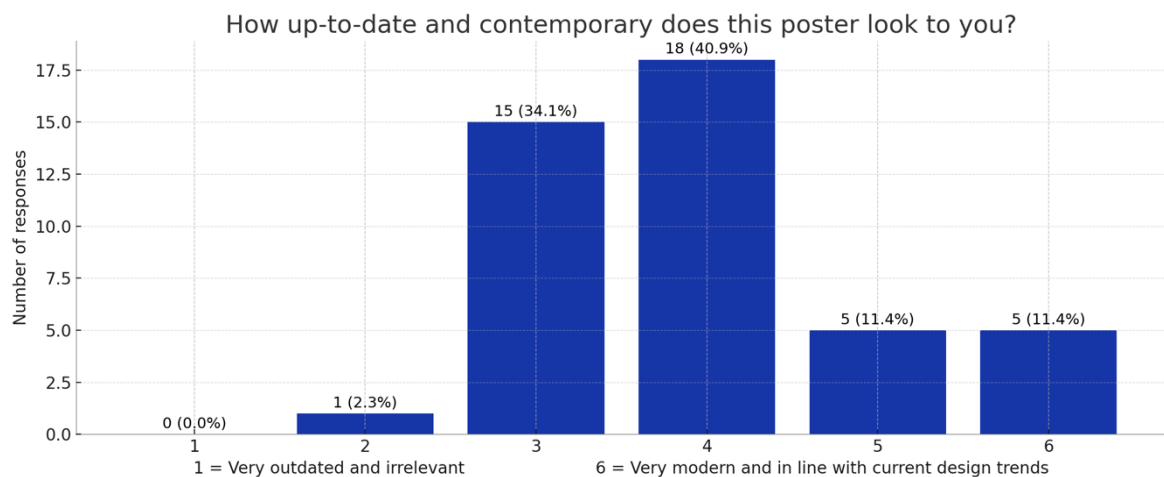


Figure 45: Results of a survey 5

Color harmony emerged as the strongest element in the overall evaluation. The average score was 4.45, and the median was 5, with most responses falling between 4 and 6. This confirms that the mix of black, white, red, green, and blue, along with the contrast between cool and warm accents, is perceived as visually well balanced.

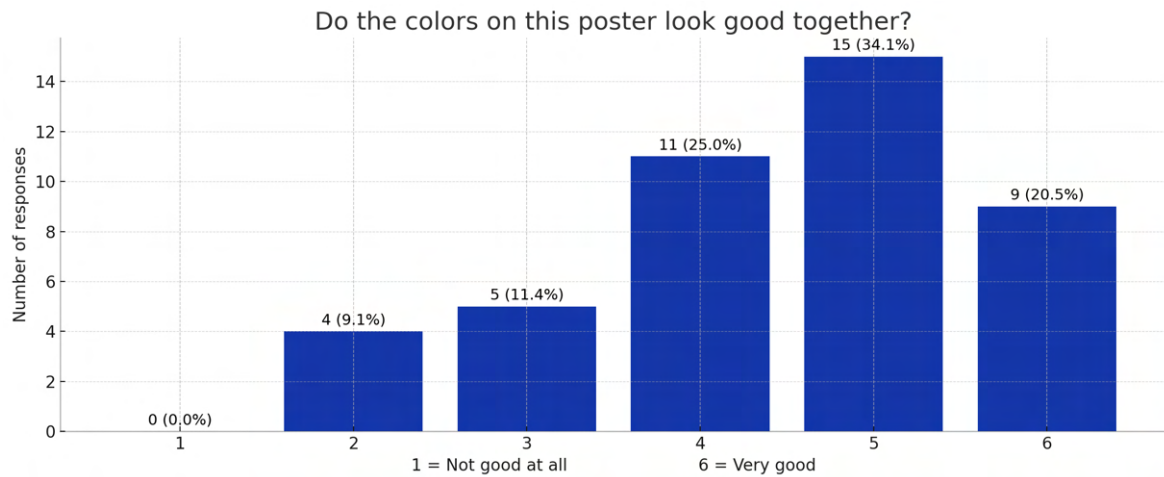


Figure 46: Results of a survey 6

The degree to which the poster encouraged interest in the film was evaluated more moderately. Because this question was shown only to respondents who had not seen the film, the total number of answers was 42. The average score was 3.45, with a median of 4, indicating that the poster can increase interest but does not do so uniformly across the audience. Scores ranged from 1 to 6, reflecting reactions from complete disinterest to strong engagement.

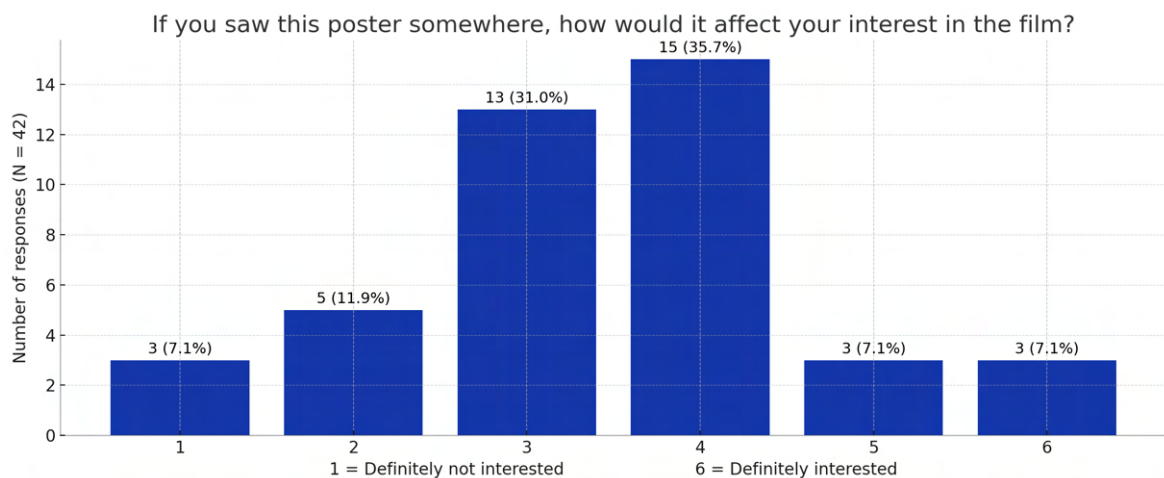


Figure 47: Results of a survey 7

As a result, a notable pattern emerged: respondents who generally enjoy horror films tended to show higher levels of interest, while those who do not typically watch horror films could still appreciate the visual qualities of the poster without expressing a desire to see the film. This suggests that the poster works well visually, but the willingness to watch the film still depends on viewers' existing genre preferences.

2.3.3 Genre Identification and Interpretation of Visual Cues

The survey also aimed to find out whether viewers could recognise the film's genre using only the visuals in the poster. Because most respondents did not know *Suspiria* (1977), their answers provide evidence of how well the poster communicates its genre. To explore how effectively the poster communicates the film's genre, the questionnaire included a structured sequence of genre-related questions. Respondents first encountered the closed question "What genre do you think this film belongs to based on the poster?", where they selected one option from a predefined list of film genres. This question served as a point of separation for two different pathways within the survey.

If a respondent selected any genre other than horror, the questionnaire directed them to an open-ended follow-up question — "What made you think this film belongs to that genre?". This allowed participants to explain which visual features influenced their decision. Here, they described their reasoning in their own words, which helps explain why some misidentified the genre.

Conversely, respondents who identified the genre as horror were directed to a different set of follow-up questions that asked which elements of the poster made it feel like horror and how clear this was to them. The same set of questions was also shown to participants who were already familiar with the film or who at least knew its genre before taking the survey. They were first asked the evaluative question "How clear is it from this poster that the film *Suspiria* is a horror movie?", presented on a six-point scale ranging from "Not clear, it doesn't look like a horror movie poster" to "Very clear, it looks like a horror movie poster." This was followed by a multiple-choice item — "Which parts of the poster make it feel like horror?" — allowing participants to select visual components such as the colours used, the composition, sharp shapes, the font, blood or red colour details, or grainy texture. They also had the option to provide their own answer instead of choosing from the predefined list.

Those who chose another genre explained their reasoning, while those who selected horror identified the elements that created this impression. This approach made it possible to understand both why some viewers misclassified the genre and which visual cues successfully communicated it.

The branching structure of the genre-identification questions produced two distinct groups of respondents. Among the 41 participants, 20 respondents (48.8%) identified the film's genre as horror, while 21 respondents (51.2%) selected a different genre. Within this second group, the most common choice was thriller, selected by 16 participants (39.0%), followed by drama (3 participants; 7.3%). Two additional respondents selected fantasy and science fiction (each 2.4%). This distribution shows that most respondents interpreted the poster as belonging to a neighbouring genre rather than recognising it as horror.

Respondents who selected a non-horror genre provided open-ended explanations, which reveal several consistent patterns. Those who chose thriller frequently referred to the poster's tense atmosphere, minimalistic composition, and sense of mystery, noting that the image suggests psychological tension rather than explicit fear. Blood and sharp shapes were often mentioned, but respondents viewed them more as suspense or danger, not as clear horror elements.

Participants who selected drama highlighted the symbolic nature of the composition, describing it as abstract or emotionally charged because of the dark background, grey fading, and the presence of blood. The single fantasy and sci-fi responses were motivated by

the poster's perceived stylisation and ambiguity, which some viewers connected with fantasy-like rather than horror stories.

The prevalence of thriller as the dominant misclassification suggests that the poster communicates a dark and suspenseful tone. Contemporary viewers often see horror and thriller as closely related genres with overlapping themes and visual elements. In the responses, the same features such as darkness, tension, blood drops, and the use of red were seen by some participants as signs of horror and by others as typical of a thriller. This shows that the genres overlap visually, and importantly, that most misclassifications did not shift toward unrelated genres such as comedy or romance. In many cases, tension, fear, and psychological unease are associated with both genres, which can make the boundary between them fluid in audience perception. From this perspective, the fact that thriller and horror were chosen in almost equal numbers suggests that the poster's restrained visual style fits both genres rather than clearly pointing to one. Its subtler style naturally leads viewers to see both genres as possible.

2.3.4 Consistency of the Visual Identity Across Additional Formats

In addition to evaluating the poster itself, the questionnaire included a supplementary question assessing whether the visual style remained consistent when applied to Blu-ray and vinyl packaging. Respondents were asked: "Do the Blu-ray and vinyl packaging keep the same look and feeling as the poster (in style, colours, and mood)?", using the same six-point scale ranging from 1 ("Not consistent at all") to 6 ("Very consistent"). This question was to confirm whether the redesigned visual identity functioned coherently across different promotional formats. The results indicated that most respondents perceived the Blu-ray and vinyl covers as stylistically aligned with the poster, suggesting that the visual language of the redesign is flexible enough to work across multiple media outputs.

The responses indicated a predominantly positive perception of consistency between the poster and the Blu-ray/vinyl packaging. The average score was 4.7 and the median was 5, showing that most respondents viewed the designs as stylistically unified. The full range of answers extended from 2 to 6, but the highest values were the most common: scores of 5–6 formed the largest share of responses (63.7%) and reflected a clear recognition of consistency in colour palette, mood, and overall visual style. Moderate evaluations of 3–4 appeared less frequently (29.5%). Very low scores, such as 2 (6.8%), were rare and likely reflected either a mismatch with personal expectations or a more literal interpretation of what consistency should look like. Overall, the responses suggest that the extended visual identity was perceived as unified and well aligned across formats.

Do the Blu-ray and vinyl packaging keep the same look and feeling as the poster (in style, colors, and mood)?

44 ответа

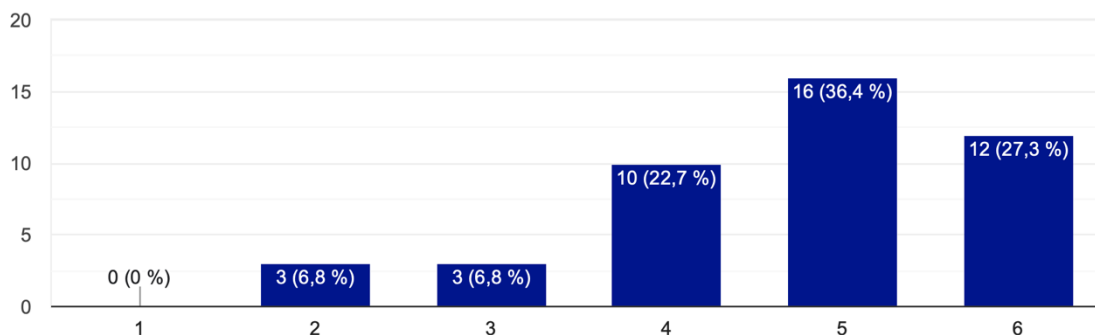


Figure 48: Results of a survey 8

2.3.5 Discussion

The results of the survey provide a valuable insight into how contemporary viewers perceive the redesigned branding of *Suspiria* (1977). At the same time, several limitations should be noted, as they influence how the findings can be interpreted.

First, the distribution of familiarity with the original film was not balanced. The overwhelming majority of participants (93.2%) had no prior knowledge of *Suspiria*, and only three respondents were familiar with the film or its genre. While this allowed the evaluation to capture “first-impression” reactions and measure how well the poster communicates genre without contextual knowledge, it also meant that the study collected very limited feedback from viewers who could assess the redesign based on their own prior understanding of the film. For future research, it would be useful to include more respondents who are familiar with *Suspiria*. Their feedback could provide a clearer understanding of how the redesign resonates with viewers who know the film’s visual style and narrative.

Second, the results showed a clear pattern: viewers who enjoy horror films became more interested in the movie after seeing the poster, while those who do not usually watch horror still rated the poster as attractive but were less inclined to see the film. This suggests that although the poster works well visually, viewers’ interest in watching the film is still shaped by their personal genre preferences, which design alone cannot fully overcome.

Third, although about half of the respondents correctly identified the poster as horror, many classified it as a thriller. However, the misclassifications stayed within closely related genres rather than shifting to unrelated categories. This shows that the poster successfully communicates a dark atmosphere, even if some viewers interpret it as more psychological than strictly horror.

Finally, the positive evaluation of consistency across the Blu-ray and vinyl designs shows that the redesigned branding works well in different formats.

Taken together, the findings from the survey highlight both the strengths of the redesigned branding and areas for further development. Future research could benefit from a larger and more diverse sample, as well as a more targeted inclusion of participants familiar with *Suspiria*.

Conclusions

The aim of this thesis is to create a modern branding for *Suspiria* that ensures genre recognizability while being visually appealing to contemporary audiences. This goal has been met through a structured combination of theoretical research, design development, and evaluation based on audience feedback.

The theoretical part established the groundwork for the practical component of the thesis. The analysis of horror posters revealed a set of recurring visual elements that play a key role in supporting genre recognition. Furthermore, the A24 case study demonstrated how contemporary film studios extend visual identity beyond traditional promotional materials, integrating it into merchandise and collectible editions to create a cohesive and multidimensional branding system.

The practical part translated these insights into the creation of a new branding concept for *Suspiria*. The redesign focused on a symbolic rather than literal interpretation of the film, with the central visual metaphor—the blue iris transforming into barbed wire—combining narrative significance with a minimalist aesthetic. This visual identity was further expanded through the development of a Blu-ray Collector's Edition and a vinyl record design, ensuring coherence across multiple formats. In response to the research question, the thesis shows that contemporary modern branding for a horror film can communicate the genre effectively to contemporary audiences through specific visual elements identified in the theoretical part, such as a dominant central motif, expressive typography, emotionally charged colour palettes, and subtle symbolic cues associated with tension or threat.

To evaluate the effectiveness of the new branding, a survey was conducted to gather feedback from viewers. Overall, the poster was perceived as visually appealing, contemporary, and well-balanced in terms of colour. Even respondents who were not familiar with the film were able to recognise the intended dark and suspenseful atmosphere. While many participants recognised the film as horror, others associated it with the closely related thriller genre. This suggests that the poster conveys tension and psychological unease, though its subtle and symbolic style may lead viewers to interpret it across a broader range of dark genres. The Blu-ray and vinyl designs were also received positively, indicating that the visual identity works consistently across different formats.

The work has several limitations. The sample included very few respondents who were familiar with *Suspiria*, which limited the possibility of comparing the reactions of those who knew the film with those encountering it for the first time. The author originally expected a higher number of participants who had seen the film, which would have allowed evaluation of how the redesign resonates with those who are familiar with the original visual style. Future studies would benefit from a more diverse and larger sample. Additionally, the thesis focused primarily on static visual outputs. Future work could therefore expand the project into dynamic and interactive media, such as motion graphics or animated trailers. Further work could also explore digital marketing materials and a complete branding system including social media presence.

Despite these limitations, the thesis shows how classic films without modern branding can be visually refreshed for contemporary audiences. The branding redesign demonstrates that

minimalism, symbolism, and propositional density can help communicate genre cues while still offering a fresh visual perspective.

Overall, this work represents both a theoretical investigation and a personal creative process. The outcomes supported by audience feedback indicate that the proposed branding successfully balances originality with genre recognisability. The thesis suggests several directions for further exploration and provides a foundation for future research in film branding, especially within the horror genre.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Link to download materials

Link to download the poster and mockups in high quality:

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1mmdatmsxcPwPo_3rxSTmoWvzt8KlZCZk?usp=sharing

Appendix B: Link to online survey

Link to online survey: <https://forms.gle/CkDnDMhQ6L9h3NnJ6>

Appendix C: Poster and mockups

The poster features a black background. In the upper left, there is a blue five-petaled flower with a green stem. A green vine with small thorns winds across the middle of the poster, passing behind the title. The title 'SUSPIRIA' is written in large, white, bold, sans-serif capital letters. From the right side of the vine, three drops of red liquid, resembling blood, are falling. The overall aesthetic is dark and mysterious, characteristic of the horror genre.

SUSPIRIA

film by DARIO ARGENTO

